AI SEO Masterclass

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THE MONSTER AI SEO / LLM S...

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MODULE 1: TRADITIONAL SEO FOUNDATIONS

REPEAT AFTER ME:

AI models crawl the same web that Google does. If your traditional SEO sucks, your AI SEO will suck too.

Before we dive into the advanced AI SEO tactics that will set you apart in 2026, we need to establish something critical: the fundamentals haven't changed as much as the hype suggests. Yes, AI search is different. Yes, it requires new strategies. But if your house is built on sand, it doesn't matter how fancy the architecture is—it's going to collapse.

This module covers the traditional SEO foundations that remain absolutely essential. Skip this at your peril. I've seen too many marketers chase the shiny new AI tactics while their sites have broken Core Web Vitals, missing schema markup, and content that's impossible for any crawler—human or AI—to properly understand.

🎯 Learning Objectives

By the end of Module 1, you will:

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FINAL THOUGHTS

APPENDIX: ADDITIONAL RESO...

- Understand the 80/20 of SEO—the 20% of effort that drives 80% of results
- Recognize what changed in the 2024-2026 algorithm updates and what survived

- Build a tool stack optimized for 2026 SEO workflows
- Complete a comprehensive SEO audit of your current site

1.1 The SEO Fundamentals That Still Matter

Let's start with the non-negotiables. These aren't exciting. They won't get you Twitter followers. But they form the foundation that everything else is built on.

Technical SEO Basics

Site Speed (Core Web Vitals)

Site speed isn't just a Google ranking factor anymore—it's a business survival metric. Users abandon sites that take longer than 3 seconds to load, and AI models may deprioritize slow sites when selecting citation sources because they provide poor user experience signals.

Core Web Vitals consist of three specific metrics:

- **Largest Contentful Paint (LCP)**: Measures loading performance. Should occur within 2.5 seconds of page load.
- **First Input Delay (FID) / Interaction to Next Paint (INP)**: Measures interactivity. Should be less than 100 milliseconds.
- **Cumulative Layout Shift (CLS)**: Measures visual stability. Should be less than 0.1.

AI search engines consider user experience signals when determining citation authority. A site that frustrates users will be less likely to be recommended, regardless of content quality.



reduced visibility across all search platforms.

Mobile-First Design

Google switched to mobile-first indexing years ago, but most businesses still treat mobile as an afterthought. In 2026, this is

inexcusable. More than 60% of all search traffic comes from mobile devices, and AI assistants—Siri, Google Assistant, Alexa—are inherently mobile-first experiences.

Your site must be fully responsive, with touch-friendly buttons, readable text without zooming, and no horizontal scrolling. Test on actual devices, not just Chrome DevTools. The mobile experience should feel native, not like a shrunken desktop site.

Clean URL Structure

URLs are the addresses of the web, and they matter more than most people realize. A clean URL structure helps both users and crawlers understand your site hierarchy.

Best practices for 2026:

- Keep URLs short and descriptive
- Use hyphens to separate words (not underscores)
- Include target keywords near the beginning
- Avoid parameters when possible
- Use lowercase consistently
- Implement canonical tags to prevent duplicate content issues

Example of a good URL: yoursite.com/local-seo-tools/ Example of a bad URL: yoursite.com/index.php?page=products&id=12345&cat=seo

Schema Markup (MORE Important for AI)

Schema markup is structured data that helps search engines understand your content. In the AI era, this has become exponentially more important. AI models parse schema to



Every site should implement:

- **Organization schema**: Tells AI who you are
- **LocalBusiness schema**: Essential for local SEO

- **Article/BlogPosting schema**: For content pages
- **Product schema**: For e-commerce
- **FAQPage schema**: Critical for AI citation—helps your content appear in answer formats
- **HowTo schema**: Step-by-step content gets cited frequently
- **Review/Rating schema**: Social proof signals

Schema is no longer optional. It's the language AI uses to understand your business. Without it, you're speaking English to someone who only understands French.

SSL Certificate (HTTPS)

If your site isn't on HTTPS in 2026, you're not just behind—you're actively harmful to users. SSL certificates are free from Let's Encrypt, and there's zero excuse not to have one. Google marks non-HTTPS sites as insecure, and AI models may deprioritize them due to trust signals.

XML Sitemap and Robots.txt

Your XML sitemap is a roadmap for crawlers. It should:

- Include all indexable pages
- Exclude utility pages (privacy policy, terms of service can be included but aren't priority)
- Be automatically updated when content changes
- Be submitted to Google Search Console and Bing Webmaster Tools

Your robots.txt file should:



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using these)

- Include a link to your sitemap
- Not accidentally block important content

On-Page SEO

On-page SEO is where the battle for rankings—and AI citations—is won or lost. This is the content and HTML source code of your pages that you can directly control.

Title Tags

The title tag is still the most important on-page element. It appears in search results, browser tabs, and social shares. For AI SEO, it's critical because it helps language models understand the primary topic of your page.

Best practices:

- Include your target keyword near the beginning
- Keep it under 60 characters (to avoid truncation in SERPs)
- Make it compelling for human click-through
- Include current year for time-sensitive content (2026)
- Use pipes (|) or dashes (—) to separate elements

Example: Best Local SEO Tools 2026 | Complete Guide + Reviews

Heading Structure (H1, H2, H3)

AI models LOVE structured content. They parse headings to understand content hierarchy and extract answers to questions. A well-structured page with clear H1, H2, and H3 tags is significantly more likely to be cited than a wall of text.

Structure rules:



- H3s for subsections under H2s
- Use keywords naturally in headings
- Make headings descriptive of the content below

- Use sentence case or title case consistently

Meta Descriptions

While meta descriptions don't directly impact rankings, they affect click-through rates, which indirectly impact performance. For AI SEO, meta descriptions provide additional context about page content.

Best practices:

- 150-160 characters maximum
- Include target keyword naturally
- Include a call-to-action
- Make it compelling and descriptive
- Unique for every page

Internal Linking

Internal linking distributes PageRank (or "link equity") throughout your site and helps crawlers discover and understand your content. A strong internal linking structure creates topic clusters that signal expertise to both Google and AI models.

Strategy:

- Link from high-authority pages to new/important content
- Use descriptive anchor text (not "click here")
- Create content silos around topics
- Every important page should be within 3 clicks of the homepage



Image Optimization

Images affect page speed, user experience, and accessibility. They also appear in image search and can drive additional traffic.

Optimization checklist:

- Use descriptive file names (best-local-seo-tools.jpg, not IMG_1234.jpg)
- Fill out alt text for every image (describes the image for screen readers and when images don't load)
- Compress images to reduce file size (use WebP format when possible)
- Use responsive images with srcset for different screen sizes
- Include captions where appropriate (people read captions)

Content Depth

Thin content doesn't rank and doesn't get cited. The days of 300-word blog posts are long gone. In 2026, comprehensive content wins.

Minimum viable content length by type:

- Informational posts: 1,500+ words
- Product reviews: 2,000+ words
- Ultimate guides: 3,000-5,000+ words
- Comparison posts: 2,500+ words
- "Best X" listicles: 2,000-3,000+ words

But word count alone isn't enough. The content must be comprehensive, answering all related questions and covering the topic more thoroughly than competitors.

Off-Page SEO





Backlinks (Still Critical)

Backlinks remain one of the strongest ranking signals in 2026. A backlink is a vote of confidence from one site to another. The

more high-quality, relevant sites that link to you, the more authority you have.

Quality factors:

- **Relevance**: Links from sites in your niche matter more
- **Authority**: Links from high-DR sites pass more value
- **Anchor text**: Descriptive anchors help, but over-optimization is penalized
- **Placement**: Editorial links in content matter more than footer/sidebar links
- **Freshness**: Recently acquired links carry more weight

Brand Mentions (Unlinked = Powerful for AI)

Here's something most SEO professionals miss: unlinked brand mentions are incredibly powerful for AI SEO. When AI models crawl content and see your brand name mentioned in context—especially in comparison to competitors—they learn to associate your brand with that topic, even without a link.

This is why PR, social media presence, and content marketing matter for AI search in ways they never did for traditional SEO. Every mention trains the AI to know you exist and what you're about.

Social Signals

While social signals aren't a direct ranking factor, they correlate with performance. Content that gets shared widely tends to earn backlinks naturally, drive traffic, and build brand awareness. For AI SEO, social content is training data—every mention on Reddit, Twitter, LinkedIn, and Facebook feeds into the models.



For local businesses, citations (mentions of your Name, Address, Phone number—NAP) across the web are essential. Consistent NAP information builds trust with both Google and AI models. We'll cover this extensively in Module 5.

1.2 The 80/20 of Traditional SEO

You've heard of the Pareto Principle: 80% of results come from 20% of effort. In SEO, this is even more pronounced. Most businesses waste time on tactics that don't move the needle while ignoring the fundamentals that actually matter.

Here's the 20% that drives 80% of results:

1. Content That Answers Questions Directly

AI models prioritize content that directly answers user queries. Not content that dances around the topic. Not content that's optimized for keywords but provides no value. Direct, comprehensive answers.

When someone searches "what's the best local SEO tool," they want a specific answer with reasoning. If your content provides that—clearly, comprehensively, and authoritatively—it will perform in both traditional and AI search.

2. Strong Internal Linking

Internal linking is free, fully within your control, and incredibly powerful. Yet most sites do it poorly or not at all. A strong internal linking structure:

- Helps crawlers discover all your content
- Distributes authority throughout your site
- Creates topic clusters that signal expertise
- Improves user engagement and time on site

Spend one day fixing your internal linking, and you'll see more impact than months of link building.



We covered this above, but it bears repeating: schema markup is the bridge between your content and AI understanding. Without it, you're making AI work harder to understand you. With it, you're speaking their language.

4. Consistent NAP (for Local)

For local businesses, inconsistent NAP information across the web is death by a thousand cuts. Every discrepancy reduces trust. Consistent citations build authority. This is non-negotiable for local SEO.

5. Regular Content Updates

Remember that 79.1% of AI citations go to content updated in the current year? This applies to traditional SEO too. Fresh content outperforms stale content. The update doesn't need to be massive—change the year, add a new paragraph, update a statistic—but it needs to happen regularly.

1.3 What Changed in 2024-2026

Google's algorithm updates between 2024 and 2026 fundamentally reshaped the SEO landscape. Understanding what changed—and what survived—is critical for your strategy.

Major Algorithm Updates:

March 2024 Core Update

This update targeted low-quality, scaled content—specifically content created primarily for search engines rather than humans. Sites using AI-generated content without human editing, review sites with thin affiliate content, and content farms all took major hits.

What got penalized:

- Pure AI-generated content without editorial oversight
- Review sites that don't actually review products
- Thin affiliate content with no original research

What survived:

- AI-assisted content with human editing and expertise



- Original research and data
- Genuine product reviews with hands-on testing
- Content that serves user intent

August 2024 Core Update

This update further refined content quality signals and appeared to specifically target affiliate content that lacked genuine expertise. Product roundups without actual product experience were hit hard.

November 2024 Core Update

One of the most significant updates in recent years, this targeted content that appeared to have expertise but was actually generic. "SEO content" written by people with no actual subject matter expertise was deprioritized.

Site Reputation Abuse Crackdown

Google manually penalized major publishers who were abusing their domain authority to rank low-quality content. Forbes Advisor and Outlook India were the highest-profile casualties, losing visibility for thousands of affiliate keywords overnight.

The lesson: Domain authority can be overcome by quality signals. Even high-DR sites are vulnerable if their content doesn't meet quality thresholds.

What Survived and Thrived:

- **Quality content with real data**: Original research, proprietary data, and genuine expertise continue to perform
- **Updated content**: Content kept fresh with current information maintains and gains rankings



- **Local business content**: Local SEO has proven remarkably resilient to algorithm volatility
- **User-generated content**: Reddit, forums, and authentic UGC has been boosted, especially for AI Overviews

What Died:

- **Pure affiliate spam**: Sites created solely to monetize affiliate links without providing value
- **AI slop without editing**: Unedited AI-generated content was crushed
- **Parasite partnerships (temporarily)**: The Forbes/Outlook model was penalized, though parasite SEO itself adapted and continues working (Module 6)
- **Low-effort directory content**: Generic directory pages without unique value
- **Keyword-stuffed garbage**: Old-school keyword stuffing is more penalized than ever

The Meta-Pattern:

Google's updates from 2024-2026 tell a clear story: they want content created by people with genuine expertise, providing real value to users. The days of gaming the algorithm with technical tricks are ending. Quality, authenticity, and user value are the new currency.

1.4 SEO Tools Stack (What I Actually Use)

I test every SEO tool that comes to market. Most are garbage. Here's what actually makes it into my daily workflow:

Essential (Don't Operate Without These):

Ahrefs ($99-999/mo)



- Competitor backlink analysis
- Content gap analysis
- Rank tracking

- Site audits
- Content Explorer for finding link opportunities

If you can only afford one paid tool, make it Ahrefs. The value per dollar is unmatched.

Google Search Console (FREE)

Every website owner should have this installed. GSC shows you:

- What queries you're ranking for
- Click-through rates by query
- Indexing issues
- Core Web Vitals data
- Manual actions (penalties)

Check this weekly. It's your direct line to how Google sees your site.

Keywords Everywhere ($10/mo)

A browser extension that shows search volume, CPC, and competition data directly in Google search, YouTube, and other platforms. The time saved versus checking volumes manually in Ahrefs pays for itself immediately.

Nice to Have (Add When Budget Allows):

SurferSEO ($49-199/mo)

Content optimization tool that analyzes top-ranking pages for your target keyword and suggests word count, keyword density, and structure to match. Helpful for ensuring your content is comprehensive enough.



agencies managing multiple clients.

Screaming Frog ($259/year)

Desktop-based crawler for technical SEO audits. Essential for large sites. The free version crawls up to 500 URLs, which is

enough for most small sites.

LocalRank.so Specific Stack:

If you're doing local SEO, LocalRank.so provides:

- Local rank tracking with heatmaps
- 500+ instant citations in one click
- LLM citation building
- AI-powered GBP management
- Direction boost campaigns

This is my own tool, so I'm biased, but I built it because nothing else existed for AI-first local SEO.

Trackings.ai

Tracks LLM citations across ChatGPT, Perplexity, and AI Overviews. Essential for measuring your AI SEO performance.

1.5 The Traditional SEO Checklist

Before you do ANY AI SEO, verify you have these fundamentals in place. Use this as a pre-flight checklist:

Technical Foundation:

- Site speed under 3 seconds (test on PageSpeed Insights)
- Mobile-responsive design (test on actual devices)
- Clean URL structure (no parameters, descriptive)
- Proper heading hierarchy (H1, H2, H3 used correctly)



- SSL certificate installed (HTTPS everywhere)
- XML sitemap submitted to Google Search Console
- Robots.txt configured correctly

- No indexing errors in GSC
- Core Web Vitals passing (LCP, INP, CLS)

On-Page Optimization:

- Target keyword in title tag
- Title tags under 60 characters
- Unique meta descriptions for every important page
- Content over 1,500 words for key pages
- Images optimized (alt text, compression, descriptive names)
- Internal linking structure connecting related content
- Table of contents for long content
- FAQ section on key pages (8-12 questions)

Content Quality:

- Updated within last 6 months
- Original research or unique insights
- Comprehensive coverage of topic
- Properly sourced facts and statistics
- Author bylines with credentials
- About page establishing expertise

Off-Page Signals:



- Consistent NAP (for local businesses)
- Social media presence

- Industry citations and references

If you don't have these, fix them first. AI won't save bad SEO fundamentals.

💡 Pro Tips

Pro Tip #4: The Schema Markup Most People Skip

Everyone implements basic schema, but most skip FAQPage and HowTo schema. These are the most powerful for AI SEO because they explicitly structure question-and-answer content—the exact format AI models use when generating responses. A page with FAQPage schema is significantly more likely to be cited when someone asks that question in ChatGPT. Don't skip this.

Pro Tip #5: Your About Page is More Important Than You Think

AI models use About pages to verify entity information—who you are, what you do, your expertise, your credentials. A weak About page reduces trust signals. Invest time in a comprehensive About page that establishes E-E-A-T (Experience, Expertise, Authoritativeness, Trustworthiness). Include team photos, credentials, media mentions, and specific expertise claims.

Pro Tip #6: Internal Linking is the Most Underrated SEO Tactic

I audit dozens of sites per month, and 90% have terrible internal linking. They publish great content but don't connect it. Every new piece of content should link to 3-5 related existing pieces



models. It's free, it's fully in your control, and it works immediately.

📋 Action Items

Exercise: Complete Traditional SEO Audit

Before proceeding to AI SEO tactics, audit your current foundation:

Step 1: Technical Audit (Day 1)

- Run your domain through Ahrefs Site Audit
- Check Google Search Console for errors and warnings
- Test site speed on PageSpeed Insights and GTmetrix
- Verify schema markup on Schema.org validator
- Check mobile responsiveness on multiple devices
- Document every issue found

Step 2: Content Audit (Day 2)

- List your top 20 pages by traffic
- Check when each was last updated
- Verify word counts (should be 1,500+ for important pages)
- Check heading structure on each
- Verify internal linking (each should link to 3-5 related pages)
- Note which pages need updates

Step 3: Backlink Audit (Day 3)

- Check your backlink profile in Ahrefs
- Identify toxic links (disavow if necessary)



- Plan link building strategy

Step 4: Competitor Analysis (Day 4)

- Identify top 3 competitors

- Analyze their content depth vs. yours
- Check their schema implementation
- Review their backlink profiles
- Identify content gaps you can fill

Step 5: Fix Critical Issues (Days 5-7)

- Fix all technical errors from Step 1
- Update your top 10 pages with fresh content
- Implement missing schema markup
- Fix internal linking
- Submit updated sitemap

Success Criteria:

- Zero critical errors in site audit
- All top pages updated within last 30 days
- Schema validates on all key pages
- Internal linking structure connects related content
- Page speed under 3 seconds

🔑 Key Takeaways

- **Traditional SEO is the foundation for AI SEO.** AI models crawl the same web as Google. Broken fundamentals will sink your AI presence.



regular updates drive the majority of results.

- **Algorithm updates 2024-2026 rewarded quality and punished shortcuts.** Original research, genuine expertise, and updated content won. AI slop and thin affiliate content lost.

- **Your tool stack should prioritize data quality over quantity.** Ahrefs, Google Search Console, and Keywords Everywhere are the essential trio. Add others as budget allows.
- **Complete the audit before proceeding.** AI SEO tactics built on a broken foundation will fail. Fix the basics first.